

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called 'The Vajra Unconquered, Bewildering Like Fire'

Ārya-vajra-ajita-anala-pramohānī-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 752 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྡོ་མེ་འཕམ་པ་མ་ལུ་རབ་ཏུ་རྡོ་སྒྲིབ་ཅེས་བརྒྱུད་གི་བུ་སྒྲིབ་

Toh 752 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-vajra-ajita-anala-pramohānī-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Pakpa Dorjé Miphamba Métar Rabtu Mongjeché Zhyabé Zung, rendered in English as "The Noble Dhāraṇī Called The Vajra Unconquered, Bewildering Like Fire." It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur, a category of texts that preserve sacred spell-formulas regarded as embodiments of enlightened power and protection. The text opens in the classical sūtra style, with the Buddha residing on a magnificent jeweled mountain peak surrounded by a vast assembly, situating the dhāraṇī within a narrative frame that lends it canonical authority. As its evocative title suggests, the text concerns a powerful dhāraṇī associated with the unconquerable, fire-like force of the vajra, invoking imagery of brilliance and overwhelming spiritual potency.

In the language of India: Ārya-vajra-ajita-anala-pramohānī-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The noble dhāraṇī called "The Vajra Unconquered, Bewildering Like Fire."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling on the supreme summit of the snowy mountain with its palace of stacked jewels, its lower slopes and waist adorned with varied golden rocks and dotted with glowing terraces, its broad flat stones shot through with the rainbow-like multicolored radiance of many jeweled rocks, its caves and forests perfumed with scattered flowers of sweet fragrance and many pleasant incenses, made beautiful with parasols, aloe wood, powders, bells, and canopies — that supreme mountain. There the Blessed One was gathered together with a great retinue assembled in a maṇḍala circle of five hundred leagues: gods and sons of gods, asuras and sons of asuras, wind-gods and sons of wind-gods, garuḍas, nāgas, yakṣas, kiṃnaras, rākṣasas, gandharvas, accomplished mantra-holders, elemental spirits, malevolent spirits, flesh-eaters, and great hosts of the mothers both visible and invisible that pervade everywhere. Together with seventy-five thousand bodhisattvas and twelve thousand five hundred monks dwelling there, the Blessed One was teaching the Dharma — teaching the Dharma that

brings ease in abiding, ease in hearing, and definite liberation from saṃsāra.

Then the gods and sons of gods, the asuras and sons of asuras, the wind-gods and sons of wind-gods, the garuḍas, nāgas, yakṣas, kiṃnaras, rākṣasas and sons of rākṣasas, gandharvas, accomplished mantra-holders, elemental spirits, malevolent spirits, flesh-eaters, hosts of the mothers both visible and invisible, and hosts of elemental spirits — all of these hosts of elemental spirits began to roam about and to cry out in sounds of panic, terror, and distress.

The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Śākyamuni, hearing those sounds, spoke these words: "O good ones, why do you cry out in sounds of panic, fear, distress, and turmoil?"

They addressed him: "Blessed One, we have come under the power of harm, and having been summoned and seized by invocation, we are about to be struck. Blessed One, we beseech your protection."

As they spoke thus, the Blessed One, with but a single thought of compassionate regard, called forth the great bodhisattva-mahāsattva who displays the vast maṇḍala over all: one possessed of supreme intelligence, wisdom, activity, and the full reach of activity; one who has progressed from a great ground to attain another ground, standing close to the regent's seat; one empowered to sovereignty over the Dharma kingdom. And he came. He had broad shoulders like a vajra quiver, a crown hard as vajra and blazing with rays of light, vajra shoulder ornaments, a body firm and solid, and he bore in his hands a vajra, a lasso, and a steady blazing implement. He thoroughly crushes with his hard vajra-kīla, possessed of great power with four hundred fifty thousand attendants, illuminating all throughout this world-realm. He came with the Young One of the vajra clan, the Vajra Host, the Vajra Weapon, the Vajra Essence, the Vajra Pinnacle, the Vajra Radiance, the Blue Vajra, the Jewel Vajra, the Secret Vajra, the Wheel-Vajra, and so forth.

He came together with the great vajra marshals, the army protectors, the earth protectors, the kings of vajra knowledge who comprehend what is genuine and what is not genuine, the vajra domains, and the vajra guides — and together with the spirit-possession entourages of the Young One of the vajra clan, the Vajra Suppressors, and the Vajra Nightmare-Makers — rousing, fully stirring, and making manifest to all gathered in the great assembly courtyard: illuminating, making fully visible, making clear, making utterly radiant, causing great rejoicing, spurring on, and rousing each one individually. He went to where the Blessed One was, removed his outer robe,

touched the crown of his head to the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated three times, joined his palms together, and sat to one side.

Then the Blessed One expressed his rejoicing and spoke: "Vajradhāra, go now and fulfill the aspirations of the gods and their sons, the asuras and their sons, the wind gods and their sons, the sky-soaring garuḍas and their sons, and all those who cry out amid the great assembly and experience distress."

Then Vajradhāra rose from his seat, entered into the midst of the assemblies of gods, asuras, wind gods, garuḍas, and spirit hosts, and showed them the way. He entered into meditative absorption called the Torch of the Vajra Weapon's Fire, and through miraculous power he caused blazing tongues of flame to pour forth rays of light, scattered fiery sparks, and pressed down upon the world-realms with crashing lightning, oppressing the world-realms throughout.

Then, for the span of five great aeons — equal in measure to dreams and waters and the grains of sand in the Ganges river — a vajra perfected through the karmic accomplishment arising from all his own luminous splendor, majesty, holy conduct, purity, patience, moral discipline, vows, ascetic practices, and all his own wealth was given into the hands of the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi.

This vajra became the means for proclaiming the scriptural Dharma of the blessed buddhas — performing the Dharma, moral discipline, and meditative absorption of the arhats who teach that Dharma; performing the perfections, moral discipline, patience, and compassion of the bodhisattvas — and served as the wrathful medium for one's own vajra, the knowledge of one's own family, and the maṇḍala transmitted through reading: taming the wrathful ones, the Lord of Death (Yama), the water deity, the ill-formed spirits, the wind gods, and the hard-to-tame sky-soaring garuḍas. In this way, the wrathful blessed Bhagavāns arising from that vajra confound the deluded, stupefy those possessed of cunning, disturb the hateful, destroy the confused, uproot the tightly bound, burst the puffed-up like bubbles, straighten the crooked, show compassion to those who cut off, terrify the spirit hosts, frighten the rākṣasas, perfect one's own secret mantras, pin down the secret mantras of others with the kīla, display efficacy, slay those who would kill, destroy those who would harm. Going there and there, they bring the gods and the sons of gods under control. In this way they rouse the wrathful ones and accomplish wrathfulness, rouse the pervaders and accomplish pervasion, rouse the asuras

and accomplish the asura state, and in general they set all of these in motion, introduce them into the maṇḍala, animate them, display power, cause forgetfulness, and cause utter terror.

By the intent declared with the ten powers, Vajradhāra spoke the dhāraṇī called the Vajra Invincible, Causing Confusion Like Fire — and through the power of this dhāraṇī —

Through the blessing of truth, rays of light from the great maṇḍala of the radiance of light stirred Vajrapāṇi, along with his vajra. That radiance rejoiced greatly, and the illuminations spreading forth from the vajra shattered the autumn stars of the three worlds and the brilliance of the moon into fragments, making the light singular alone. They dried up the great ocean, shook Mount Meru, the king of mountains, resounded with the wheel of lightning and the dragon whose tongue flickers, released a fierce sound, proclaimed a reverberating roar, and caused terror.

Then the Blessed Lady known as Vajradhāra, the Daughter of the Vajra — she who abides within the great blazing fire-form of the dhāraṇī called Vajra Invincible, Causing Confusion Like Fire, her mass of hair like gold and precious jewels — having circled three times, with a mind swifter than thought, her awareness blazing and flaring like a flame, went for refuge with great force to the bodhisattva of great supernatural power, the great being.

When she arrived, the noble Vajrapāṇi spoke: "O greatly fortunate and virtuous one, you who are endowed with mind through the Tathāgata's meditative absorption — grant power to these, in accordance with their weapons." Then the dhāraṇī said in reply: "I will do exactly as you have commanded" — and spoke these words three times.

The three topknots; the three worlds; the three times; the three wrathful tips; the wheel of Viṣṇu; the club of Yama; the club of the Vetāla; the vajra of Indra; the noose of Varuṇa; the obstacles of the demons who lead astray; the illusions of the asuras; the splendor and force of the wind gods; the confounders of the siddhas; the cutters of the assemblies of the Mātṛs; the pledges and poisons of the nāgas; the wrathful ones; the yakṣas; the rākṣasas; the kiṃnaras; the flesh-eaters; the spirits; the brahma-rākṣasas; the grulbums; the truthless ones; the oppressors; those who attack at the time of the zombie — all of these likewise: cleanse them all! In a mere instant, with just the flutter of an eye, all of these were worshipped, and then she offered this essence to Vajrapāṇi and spoke:

"Homage to the Three Jewels! Homage to Vajrapāṇi the wrathful, the great general of the yakṣas!"

Tadyathā: tathāgatasamādhidhāraṇī mahāāvartayiṣyāmi ahivajre kuṭile kuṭivākākualāśikhi kapilakeśi taṭiṭiṭimaṭani karkaṭamuṭibaṭṭivajre mahābidhullolole buguPulu sumuSumu sarsara phaṭphaṭ sudyote piṃgalecite vicaṭi jvalapingale sarvadevaGaṇa praharaṇamāyā siddhādāyikesuruke suruke vajraghoṇe vajradviḍha sārāpraharaṇe ratnatraya dikralaBuddhete vajradharaviśvasanike apratihatapramardani svāhā.

Whoever recalls this secret mantra and reads, meditates upon, or holds it — hearing it within, they will not fall into downfall or go to a bad rebirth. They will have made offering to all maṇḍalas, worldly and transcendent. They will enter into the pledges and seals. By intention and empathetic joy they will be summoned. They will cause terror in the face of dangers such as poison, secret mantras, knots, blows, and binding.

Then, by the power of those gods and sons of gods, and by experiencing in many various ways the sport of the Blessed One Vajradhāra and the manifold teachings spoken by the Blessed One, the gods of the pure realms above — of Akaniṣṭha — and

those dwelling in other world-systems worshipped with radiant flowers, with clouds of incense, and with a great rain of many precious jewels, and then praised with lovely words of praise — verses pleasant and profound, like the sound of a drum, cool and filled with merit.

After the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks, those bodhisattvas, and all the assembled retinue were filled with joy and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Indestructible Vajra, Utterly Confounding Like Fire."

Translator's Notes

- The text presents a long series of supernatural being-types in the assembly. "Wind-gods" renders a term for vāyu-class deities. "Mothers both visible and invisible" renders a term for visible and invisible mātṛ-goddesses, a class of fierce protective female deities. "Malevolent spirits" renders a term for a class of harmful spirit-guides. The phrase translated as "one who has progressed from a great ground to attain another ground, standing close to the regent's seat, empowered to sovereignty over the Dharma kingdom" is a dense technical description of Vajrapāṇi's bodhisattva stage and role, describing him as a tenth-ground bodhisattva near the state of a dharma-king's regent — the standard honorific depiction of Vajrapāṇi in dhāraṇī

literature. The entity summoned is Vajrapāṇi, who arrives with his retinue of vajra-beings, each listed by epithets.

- The phrase rendered "the Vajra Nightmare-Makers" translates a term meaning those who cause bad dreams by means of the vajra; the rendering stays close to the literal sense, which appears to be a specific class of spirit-retinue rather than a metaphor.

The passage "for the span of five great aeons — equal in measure to dreams and waters and the grains of sand in the Ganges river" is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan; "dreams and waters" may refer to a specific cosmological or literary enumeration whose precise referent is unclear from this passage alone.

The term rendered "ill-formed spirits" translates a word meaning beings of ugly or malformed body, a class of spirit.

- The mantra transliteration preserves the Tibetan phonetic rendering as faithfully as possible. Several syllables are phonetically ambiguous or show scribal variation; the rendering here follows the Tibetan letter by letter without emendation, as is standard practice for transmitted mantras.

The term "grulbum" is a class of malevolent spirit in Tibetan demonology with no standard Sanskrit equivalent and no universally accepted English rendering; it is left in transliteration.

"The three wrathful tips" likely refers to the trident associated with Śiva; the phrase "wrathful three-pointed" may also refer to a weapon type. This is left close to the Tibetan.

The transition at the end is mid-sentence in the Tibetan, indicating the passage continues; the translation reflects this open ending.

- The final line is a colophon-style title identifying the text. "འཕགས་པོ་མཁའ་ལྔ་པ་" literally means "unconquerable" or "invincible," and in this compound with "འཕགས་པོ་མཁའ་ལྔ་པ་" yields "Indestructible Vajra" or "Invincible Vajra." The rendering "indestructible" is chosen to capture both the vajra's nature and the dhāraṇī's protective force. "འཕགས་པོ་མཁའ་ལྔ་པ་" means "causing utter bewilderment / confusion," rendered here as "utterly confounding" in the sense of vanquishing or stupefying adversarial forces, consistent with the apotropaic context of the preceding passage.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.